worthy of this obligation and trust of the members and candidate members of the Central Committee and our whole party'.2 Later that evening, a congratulatory telegram arrived from Brezhnev, it was sincere and heartfelt:

Soviet communists view the decision of the plenum of the SED Central Committee to elect you, Comrade Honecker, to the post of First Secretary of the SED Central Committee and Comrade Walter Ulbricht to the post of chairman of the party as an embodiment of the important Leninist principle of the continuity and collectivity of party leadership, as a pledge of the firm determination of communists, of all working people of the GDR to follow the principled course toward creating a developed social system of socialism in the GDR, toward the utmost strengthening of the republic as an inalienable part of the fraternal-community of socialist states, toward ensuring a stable peace and the strengthening of European security.

3

In his message of congratulation, Russian ambassador Abrasimov praised Honecker as an 'outstanding official of the working class' and lauded the SED for its 'inflexible struggle against West German imperialism, its consistent course towards the complete demarcation against the imperialist FRG, and the deep integration of the GDR into the community of socialist states'.4

Having victoriously survived fifty years of purges and power struggles, Walter Ulbricht – a man who had done a great deal to mythologise himself – slipped quietly into official oblivion. He commandeered the headlines for the last time on 4 May, when Neues Deutschland noted: 'The Central Committee assured Comrade Ulbricht that, under the leadership of its First Secretary, Comrade Erich Honecker, the great work of building the socialist